



Participatory action research · volunteer-run

Positionality Workbook

A reflection tool for co-researchers and members of the peer-review board.

// WHY POSITIONALITY

Your positionality is the way in which your perceptions and research activities are shaped by the frameworks and sociopolitical context within which you live.

In (action) research, it is important to recognise how your experience, values, norms and belief systems influence your sensemaking — what you see and emphasise versus what you neglect and miss. It also helps us understand each other better.

Part A — Personal reflection

Yours alone. Sharing is entirely optional.

Part B — Impact on the research

We will discuss this together, at your comfort level.

BASED ON

Learn more about the positionality tool and its purpose in Cooper et al. (2024), sent alongside this workbook.

NAME _____

DATE _____

Two parts, two levels of sharing

The tool asks you to reflect first on yourself (Part A), and then on how this shapes the research project (Part B). Write directly in this booklet — it is designed to be printed. Take your time with each question and don't rush it.

PART A — FOR YOUR EYES ONLY

Part A is purely for personal reflection. We will not ask you to hand it in, read it aloud, or share it with anyone.

You are of course free to volunteer whatever details you feel comfortable sharing — but that is entirely your choice, and there is no expectation whatsoever.

PART B — DISCUSSED MORE OPENLY

Part B will be discussed more openly in the group. Knowing each other's blind spots and biases helps us notice and address the gaps in our research.

Here too, you decide what you volunteer. Share what you are comfortable with — nobody is asked to disclose more than that.

TIPS

■ Treat friction as data.

Frustration, irritation and discomfort with these questions are sources of curiosity. Friction often reveals underlying bias.

■ Perfect answers are impossible.

Positionality is messy and dynamic — and that is exactly what reflexivity is about.

■ Sit with each question.

Especially in Part B. Don't rush to the tidy answer; notice the one you'd rather not write down.

// PART A

Personal reflection

Answer these for yourself. Sharing is entirely optional.

REMINDER

This part is yours. We will not collect it or ask you to share it. Volunteer only what you feel comfortable with.

1

What social identities do you use to describe yourself? This includes nationality, gender, race, profession, disability, ethnicity, religion, age and more. Where are these situated with respect to dominant cultures and norms, privileges and marginalization?

2

What are defining themes from your lived experience? This includes education, family, professional development and influential life events. How do these experiences affect your ability to empathize with others with different lived experiences, and to understand issues relevant to diverse lived experiences?

3

What are your epistemic beliefs? What is required for you to consider something "knowledge"? What are characteristics of beliefs you would not qualify as knowledge? What sources produce reliable knowledge? Where are your beliefs situated with respect to dominant culture and norms?

4

What are your affiliations? What organizations, institutes or companies do you represent?

Impact on the research

How your answers to Part A shape this project.

The following questions ask you to reflect on how your answers in Part A might influence the research topics, the methodology, and what interests and energizes you. Take your time to sit with each question, and don't rush it.

WHAT WE'LL DO WITH THIS

We may ask you to share what you feel comfortable sharing from this part. Knowing how each other's positionality influences our focus helps us find blind spots and close gaps. You remain in control of what you volunteer.

- 1 How do your social identities, lived experience, epistemic beliefs and affiliations relate to the topic of this project and its framing?

- 2 How do your social identities, lived experience, epistemic beliefs and affiliations relate to your research priorities, research questions, and the framing and justification of these questions?

3

Based on your social identities, lived experience, epistemic beliefs and affiliations, how are you similar to (an insider) and different from (an outsider) current and potential participants?

4

How do your social identities, lived experience, epistemic beliefs and affiliations influence project protocols? What do you assume about daily life, abilities, personal experience and beliefs that might be different for others?

5

How do your social identities, lived experience, epistemic beliefs and affiliations relate to your sense of responsibility and obligations to the interests, values and priorities of participants?

6

How might your social identities, lived experience, epistemic beliefs and affiliations increase insights, or lead to blind spots, in reciprocity in design?

7

How do your social identities, lived experience, epistemic beliefs and affiliations shape how you share leadership with people with attributes that differ from yours?

BEFORE THE SESSION

Mark the answers you are happy to share out loud.